

Self-reported phenomenology following repeated M-ZRT sessions

Florian Morin, Independent Researcher

FlorianMorin.com

May 25, 2026

Abstract

This self-described state emerged after several sessions, approximately five, of M-ZRT, a brief procedure lasting around 20 seconds per session and aimed at reducing the “evaluative gain”. The transition clearly appeared during one of these sessions. During the acute transition phase, there was unusually stable mental imagery, intense “joy”, and various associated symptoms lasting around 48 hours, followed by a stable daily state that persisted for at least six months. This very short paper focuses on the latter. It attempts to describe the subjective experience of the hypothesized “ease regime” once access had been unlocked through the M-ZRT task.

This text mixes several levels of description and contains some awkwardness. But it should be remembered that it is an attempt to describe a particular state, one that is difficult to put into words. Some aspects, I think, cannot really be described properly, I can only approximate an accurate description. So at times the text may appear not so much strange as creative, because describing something subjective is extremely difficult, and at certain moments, as you will see, it may even be impossible.

Introduction

The Regime Theory of Joy seeks to explain this phenomenon through a specific brain configuration characterized by reduced evaluative gain coupled with a high capacity for salience processing. The framework also attempts to explain the apparent high prevalence of joy during childhood and its relative rarity in adulthood, its possible relationship to the Free Energy Principle and related theoretical frameworks, and how access to this regime may re-emerge in adults through task designs such as the so-called “M-ZRT”. The latter involves non-instrumental actions, suspension of optimization, openness exercises, and salience-based exercises (1). The present article describes a self-observational account of the ease regime after the acute transition phase, focusing on how the state behaves once stabilized over time.

The author anticipates that some readers may interpret the present report as reflecting an idiosyncratic altered state, introspective overinterpretation, or a psychiatric-like phenomenon rather than a genuine affective regime transition. Such interpretations are understandable given the unusual phenomenology described here. However, the primary goal of this text is not to establish definitive causal claims, but to document a coherent experiential pattern that appeared repeatedly after a very brief and structured behavioral procedure. The hope is that the report may motivate a small number of sufficiently open-minded and methodologically careful researchers to experimentally test whether procedures such as the M-ZRT can, under specific conditions, produce reproducible changes in affective accessibility, evaluative processing, or perceptual salience dynamics.

The ease regime at six months post-transition

The state has two main modes. The first, which I call “being moved,” and the second, which I call “energetic,” both have chest pleasure as their primary feature. The state shifts from one mode to the other in a relatively unpredictable manner. The state collapses after exposure to evaluative environments, but returns once outside those environments, although recovery can occur within twenty minutes or take several days.

Mode “being moved”

This mode resembles a near-sadness state. It does not feel sad in the ordinary sense, because the emotional trajectory seems to stop just before becoming negative. In this mode, music can become emotionally overwhelming, especially lower-toned material such as children’s songs, light-themed but slightly melancholic older songs, or emotionally simple melodies. Lower-tone visual environments, such as Christmas decorations, also appear to intensify the state. Subjectively, this mode strongly resembles what could be described as “childhood joy.”

Phenomenologically, the experience is often accompanied by thoughts such as: “It is moving, it is interesting, it is fabulous”.

What do I think when it happens (subjective experience): “This mode is consistently moving in part because it closely resembles the type of emotional experience commonly associated with childhood. It feels fairly intense and aesthetically beautiful, not sad, but deeply moving.”

Mode “Energetic”

Strong sense of mastery, but not narcissistic. Chest-pleasure in this mode is modulated by higher-energy music, and highly salient images, lights. Odors, sounds, are clearly augmented. It’s a mixture of being euphoric yet calm. It is euphoric in the sense there is a “high” feel, a strong chest-pleasure, yet it is quiet, in the sense that it is just calm.

Images or videos of people displaying strong bodily confidence appear to increase the intensity of the thoracic pleasure state. In addition, stimuli containing prediction-error characteristics associated with older cartoons, such as exaggerated timing, and unexpected perceptual transitions, are also associated with stronger intensity increases.

What does it compare to? I would say it is somewhat similar to the early subjective phase of tramadol before tolerance sets in, minus the sedative effect. Here, I am mainly speaking to people who understand the type of experience being referenced. As stated earlier, there is no true point of comparison, which is why I often have to rely on imperfect analogies to describe the state phenomenologically. The main difference with Tramadol is that the state feels clean, with responses remaining consistently tied to prediction errors.

What do I think when it happens (subjective experience): “This is strong chest-pleasure, sometimes it feels “full bandwidth”, modulated by aesthetics and simple visuals. It is highly boredom-resistant. For that reason, it represents the main interest and central distinguishing property of the state.”

Golden tint (visual)

Scenes often take on a warm golden tint, contributing to a richer perceptual quality. The intensity is variable. It is only within the “being moved” mode.



Normal coloration, or within the ease regime energetic



The ‘ease regime being moved mode vision’ at maximal intensity. The golden tint vary in intensity. White elements also produce a snow-like perceptual feeling or texture, a feature not captured by the image.

What do I think when it happens (subjective experience): “Yes, this is joy.” It is like a signal that the state is here. It is not particularly rewarding.

Jewels raining

This one is pretty strange. I got the possibility to imagine jewels, that’s it, emeralds, rubies, gemstones, simply flowing just in front of my eyes. It’s natural, relatively pleasant. It’s not the most interesting feature: as the golden-tint, it mostly signals that joy is here.

What do I think when it happens (subjective experience): “I like that”, et “yes, the state is here”. Strangely, I can only do it in one direction, like a rain. I can’t, for example, imagine jewels on a wall, floor, or flowing in reverse direction, from floor to the sky. It’s interesting, but it’s not a “major feature” to live, despite the strangeness of the description.

The joy feeling.

Not being content, not being happy, but a joy feeling immediately tagged without ambiguity, as being joy. At that moment, it is easy to imagine smiling faces, but not other objects. It is very different, very distinctive. I am not able, at this time, to put words that would actually describe it. Because there is nothing to compare to. That “true joy” feeling, however, is relatively rare. It lasts more around some minutes than hours. It is more likely to happen when sensory stimulation is here. Especially low-stake music, where nothing really happens, where no meaningful message is emphasised.

What do I think when it happens (subjective experience): “Yes, this is obviously joy” and immediately, “I’m not able to communicate it”, and “waw, that’s amazing”. It often leaves me a bit shocked, mostly because of the distinctiveness, and the “This is joy, I can’t believe it! This is like a gift!” subjective feeling..

Moderate entity feeling

Sometimes, it feels as though joy is some kind of entity. As if joy were almost a guest. It is a bit uncanny, but in reality, this sensation is pleasurable.

What do I think when it happens (subjective experience): “Joy is here, but don’t care about anything. It seems like a skilled, confident guest. This thing knows what it does.”

Spontaneous internal selection

The system appears to automatically scan stored songs or video-clips, and bring forward the one that best fits the current state. This is experienced as being “called,” rather than deliberately chosen. Sometimes, the brain simply “plays” the selected item, reliably increasing the intensity of joy.

The hippocampal-like completion feeling

As already explained, some properties of the state are difficult to communicate. The following is probably the most difficult. This is nowhere near nostalgia. Nostalgia often carries a sense of loss and remains relatively controllable. Here, the state is intense, not controllable, and completely lacks the feeling of loss.

What is striking is that when I look at a tiny object resembling childhood objects, the exact same feeling returns immediately, often with very high intensity. It is not experienced as a vague autobiographical memory, but as the sudden reappearance of a fully familiar perceptual texture. The sensation feels exact, immediate, and involuntary.

Different objects appear to carry completely different ‘textures’. For example, while walking through a shopping mall, multiple objects and odors may spontaneously trigger distinct familiar textures within minutes, often unexpectedly, because the process does not feel voluntarily controlled. The recognition emerges on its own.

Colors can also become unusually intense and almost consumable, as if I were ‘eating a candy’, again with a strong sense of familiarity. Importantly, the experience is not: ‘I remember this.’ It is closer to: ‘Oh damn, this is it.’ The state feels like direct re-access to a specific mode of experience rather than recollection about the past.”

The distinction between “this is it” and “I remember that” is actually very important phenomenologically. The first implies immediate re-instantiation of a perceptual-affective configuration, while the second implies reflective autobiographical recall from a distance.

It appears that exercises I refer to as salience exercises tend to make this mode emerge relatively quickly (1)..

Paradoxical Effects

A paradoxical effect was repeatedly noted: attempts to suppress the state, for example when an important task requires immediate attention, often appear to increase the probability of strong intensity rather than reduce it. One possible interpretation is that the abrupt interruption of ordinary optimization dynamics transiently destabilizes ongoing evaluative control.

In addition, migraine episodes were consistently associated with increased state intensity, suggesting that certain large-scale alterations in sensory, attentional, or predictive regulation may temporarily facilitate access to the state rather than inhibit it.

Conclusion

The present report should not be interpreted as definitive evidence for the existence of a distinct affective regime. Its primary limitation is methodological: the observations are based on a single self-report, without external validation, independent measurements, replication, control conditions, or objective temporal tracking. As such, alternative interpretations, including idiosyncratic altered-state phenomena, remain possible.

However, the consistency of the phenomenology, the apparent reproducibility of some features across sessions, and the reported emergence of the transition during a brief and structured procedure may justify cautious experimental investigation. At minimum, the present observations suggest that unusually intense and distinctive affective configurations may exist that are difficult to capture within standard evaluative or laboratory contexts.

The aim of this paper is therefore not to conclude that the proposed “ease regime” has been demonstrated, but rather to document a coherent experiential pattern that could motivate future controlled research on evaluative processing, salience dynamics, and the accessibility of high-intensity positive affective states

Conflict of interest: the author is the creator of the theory and the method.

Reference:

Morin, F. (2026). A Regime Theory of Joy: The Ease Regime as a Permissive Control Configuration. *SSRN*, <https://dx.doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.6711318>